Differences in MLB Pitch Mix from the Week of 8/15, 2015-2025

I looked at pitch distribution over the course of 11 MLB seasons, but only those occurring in one specific week (8/15-8/21), to see how usage has or has not changed over time. The table below shows the most popular pitch types and their differences in usage over this timespan.

Pitch Type	% of all pitches (2015)	% of all pitches (2025)	Change (Percentage Pts.)
Slider / Sweeper	14.7%	22.7%	**8.0**
Splitter	1.82%	3.05%	1.23
Cutter	5.88%	7.10%	1.22
Slurve	0.01%	0.36%	0.35
Changeup	10.40%	10.60%	0.20
Curveball	10.40%	8.56%	-1.84
Four-Seam	36.60%	32.20%	-4.40
Sinker / Two-Seam	20.10%	15.40%	**-4.70**

The most drastic changes in pitch usage are seen in the increase in slider/sweeper and the decrease in the sinker/two-seam, followed closely by the four-seam.

Slider / Sweeper: After some outside research, I found that the slider-variation of the sweeper became prominent in the 2020-2023 seasons, up to 10,000 of the pitches being added into the count each year (Christie). This is the likely explanation for the large increase in usage, the weight most likely being carried by the sweeper in the grouping.

From 2015 to 2025, the slider/sweeper category saw an increase of 8.00 points, from 14.70% to 22.70%. The increase in usage could be because of the pitch's tendency to draw weak contact, leading to typically easy plays for the defense, or otherwise swings and misses (MLB).

Four-Seam Fastball: Since 2015, the distribution of fastballs has decreased over 4.40 points. This could be making room for other pitches, and considering batters' adapting to high speeds over an 11 season span.

The four-seam fastball still is the most used pitch in the distribution at 32.20%. It is the fastest and straightest pitch, typically the easiest to place in the zone (MLB). So although its usage did decrease some from 2015 to 2025, it will never be phased out.

Sinker / Two-Seam: There is a 4.70% decrease in sinker/two-seam usage from 2015 to 2025. The pitch is intended to be fast, but not as fast as a four-seam, with a tendency to force ground balls and limit home runs (MLB). Perhaps the decrease in usage was to focus on pitches with more swing and miss probability.

Differences in Chicago White Sox Pitch Mix from the Week of 8/15, 2015-2025

Pitch Type	% of all Pitches (2015)	% of all Pitches (2025)	Change (Percentage Pts.)
Splitter	2.53%	0.47%	-2.06
Cutter	5.68%	8.53%	2.85
Changeup	13.80%	11.40%	-2.40
Slider / Sweeper	16.10%	18.7%	2.60
Curveball	9.68%	11.30%	1.62
Four-Seam	26.60%	31.80%	**5.20**
Sinker / Two-Seam	25.60%	17.80%	**-7.80**

We see that the most drastic of changes come in the form of an increase in four-seam usage and a decrease in the sinker/two-seam.

Something to note here compared to the league-wide output is that there is no slurve. This is because the data indicated no slurve usage during 8/15-8/21 of both 2015 and 2025 seasons for the Chicago White Sox. Even for the league wide output, the usage only made up 0.01% of pitches in the MLB in 2015, so for this pitch to not be used at all is not necessarily surprising.

Four-Seam Fastball: The distribution of fastballs for the White Sox from 2015 to 2025 has increased from 26.60% to 31.80%, by 5.20 points.

In 2015, the White Sox's four-seam fastball usage was 10.00 points lower than the league-wide rate (36.60%). In 2025, it was within 0.40 points of the league rate of 32.20%.

Sinker / Two-Seam: There is a 7.80 point decrease (25.60% to 17.80%) in sinker/two-seam usage from 2015 to 2025.

In 2015 the White Sox's sinker/two-seam usage was 5.5 points higher than the league (20.10%). Their usage in 2025 is still above the league by 2.40 points (15.40%).

Together, the two comparisons show the White Sox's fastball mix moving toward the league average over the period. Because each season is a single week of about 6 to 7 games, differences of a few points could reflect week-to-week usage, not a lasting change.

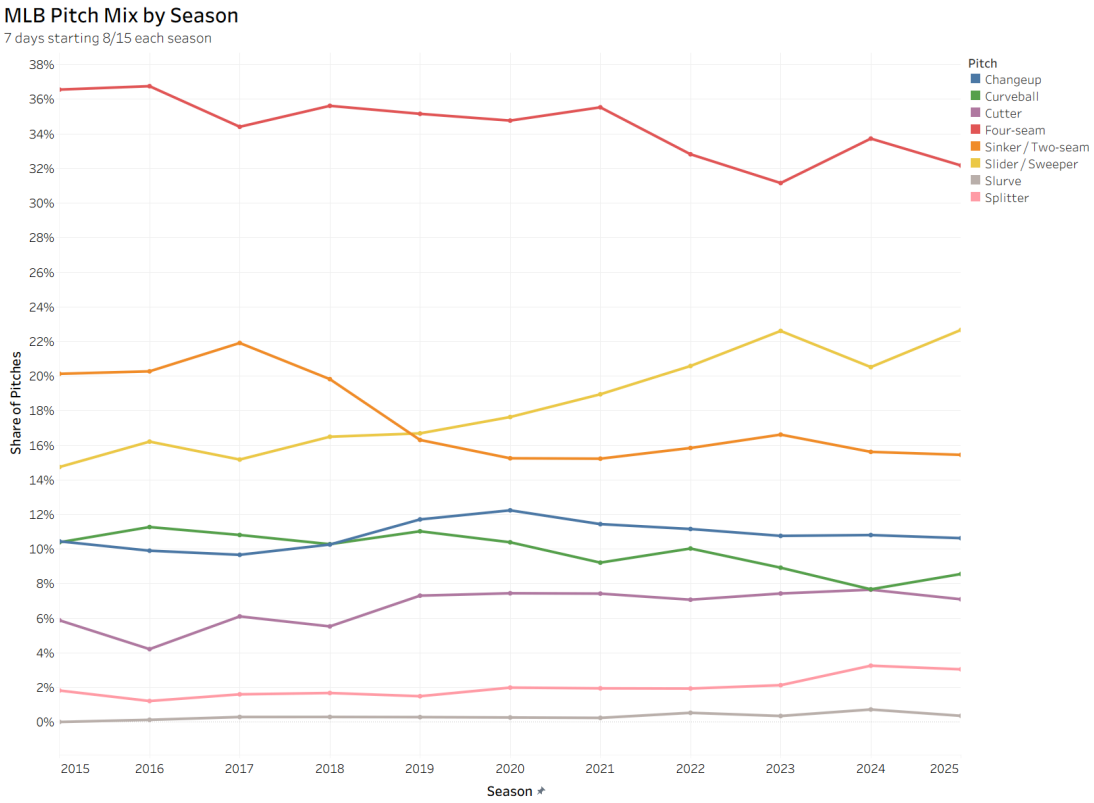
Data

This data comes over the course of 11 MLB seasons (2015-2025), looking at one week in August (8/15-8/21) brought 310,162 pitches recorded from the pitch-level Statcast data from Baseball Savant through the baseballr package in R. After removing rare pitches such as intentional balls, knuckleballs, etc., which accounted for 2,635 rows, or less than 1% of pitches combined. This left 307,527 rows pitches to observe.

I chose one week of the season for less of a data load, and the time it would take to process the sheer amount of pitches thrown in a season, let alone 11.

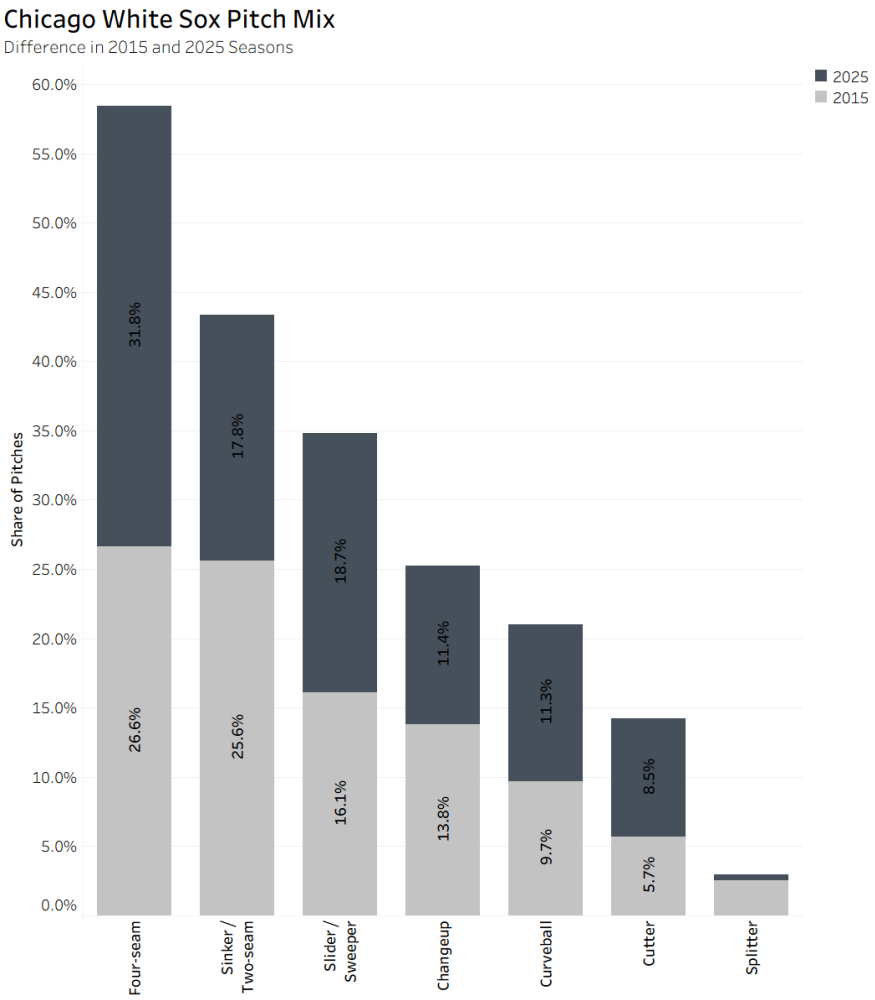
I combined the sinker and two-seam pitch categories because originally they were separate in different years. As well as sliders and sweepers, which are variations.

Visual Findings



This multi-line chart represents one pitch type per line. We see the four-seam fastball, in green, dominates the share of pitches across all 11 seasons, ranging from approximately 36%-32%.

An interesting occurrence depicted in this visualization is seen in the switch of the sinker/two-seam and the slider/sweeper. The slider/sweeper gained popularity in 2020, so this steep increase in usage does make sense, but the previous decline in sinker/two-seam is curious.



This stacked bar chart shows the difference in Chicago White Sox pitch usage from only the 2015 and 2025 seasons. It visualizes the increased usage of the four-seam fastball compared to the decrease in sinker/two-seam in 2025, which were at similar rates in 2015. Something else noticeable is the sinker/two-seams' previously similar usage to the four-seam decreased significantly (-7.8) by 2025. Additionally, the splitters' small share only got smaller.

Limitations

Each season is represented by a single week (8/15-8/21), which may not reflect the full season, even across 11 seasons. This matters most for the White Sox results, which rest on only 6 to 7 games per season, so differences of a few points could come from week-to-week variation instead of a lasting change. Pitch choice also depends on the batters faced and the opponents that week, which one week cannot capture. Mid-August rosters typically differ from early-season rosters, so choosing that week could introduce bias.

Rare pitches, such as knuckleballs and intentional balls, were removed. They made up less than 1% of the data, so they are unlikely to change the league-wide results. Sliders and sweepers were combined into one category because Statcast only began labeling sweepers separately in 2023, so this analysis cannot show how much each pitch contributed to that group's increase.

This analysis is descriptive. It shows how pitch usage changed, but not why, so any explanations offered are possibilities, not findings. A larger project could use full seasons or several weeks per season.

Conclusion

MLB pitch usage from 2015 to 2025 shifted toward sliders and sweepers, while sinker/two-seam and four-seam fastball usage declined league-wide.

The Chicago White Sox showed an increased four-seam usage while decreasing sinker/two-seam usage, bringing their pitch mix closer to league averages.

Although these results highlight meaningful differences in pitch distribution, the one-week sample limits conclusions about long-term trends and the reasons behind these changes.

AI Disclaimer

I was assisted by Claude, an AI assistant developed by Anthropic, as a support tool for this project.

It helped me write and troubleshoot R code, and edit the wording of this write-up. I ran the code, pulled and checked the data, and reviewed the results myself, and I am responsible for the analysis, interpretations, and conclusions presented here.

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